

CORE FORMULA

Notice -> Pause -> Name the non-fix -> Reflect -> Mode check -> Continue or shift. -> Ultra-short:
"Not fixing yet. Listening first." -> Field line: I hear the problem, I won't fix it yet, I'll stay with the person, and I'll ask what kind of help is wanted before advising. -> "I can see why this is heavy. I won't jump into fixing it yet — do you want me to just listen for a minute, or help you sort options?" -> "I'm not going to silver-line it. What part is sitting heaviest?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say one non-fixing line — "I won't try to fix this yet. I can just stay with you in it for a minute." — then listen and reflect before offering any solution.

BEST FOR

- Venting, overwhelm, grief, shame, disappointment, rejection, burnout, frustration, anxiety, or confusion
- A friend, partner, colleague, client, or family member who says something painful and pauses
- Moments when your first instinct is "you should," "just," "at least," "why don't you," or "here's what I'd do"
- Leadership conversations where the person needs to feel understood before any action planning
- Support conversations where the practical answer isn't clear yet
- Texts where instant advice would feel cold or transactional

PHRASE BANK

Quick · One-liners

- "Not fixing yet. Listening first."
- "That sounds like a lot. I'm here."
- "That sucks. I can just listen."
- "I won't try to fix this yet. I can just stay with you in it for a minute."
- "I can feel myself wanting to solve it. Let me not rush you."
- "No fixing unless you want it."
- "I'm here. Take your time."

Friend & partner · Close relationships

- "I'm not going to hit you with advice unless you ask. Tell me the part that's weighing on you."
- "Want me to stay in friend mode, or help you make a plan?"
- "I'm hearing you. I don't want to turn this into me managing you."
- "Let me not fix. What do you need from me right now?"
- "I can hold this with you before we decide anything."
- "I know I jump into solutions. I'm going to slow down."
- "That sounds awful. I won't fix it yet — what part is most frustrating?"
- "I know I usually try to solve this. What do you need from me right now?"

Work & leadership · Professional

- "Before we solve, I want to understand the impact on you and the team."
- "I won't jump straight to actions. What should I understand first?"
- "Do you want me in listening mode, coaching mode, or decision mode?"
- "Let's separate being heard from deciding the next step. Start with what happened."
- "Before I assign fixes, I want to understand where the pressure's actually coming from."
- "I'm not going to rush into a generic fix. First, what has this disrupted for you?"

- "Now that I understand it, let's choose the smallest step that helps."

Mode menu · Ask what they want

- "Do you want listening first, or help thinking through options?"
- "Do you want comfort, outrage, distraction, or problem-solving?"
- "Do you want listening, comfort, or ideas?"
- "Do you want me in friend mode, coach mode, or practical mode?"
- "Do you want to vent first or solve now?"
- "Before we talk answers, what's the hardest part of this right now?"
- "What would actually help from me right now?"

Own the slip · Soften & de-escalate

- "That came out more advice-y than I meant. I can just listen."
- "I think I tried to make it tidy too quickly. It might just be messy right now."
- "I may have sounded like I was minimising it. That wasn't fair."
- "Let me separate two things: I care, and I don't need to control the next step."
- "I'm not going to silver-line it. What part is sitting heaviest?"
- "I do have thoughts, but I don't want to rush past what this is like for you."

Pressure & safety · High-stakes

- "We may need action, but first I want to understand what you're dealing with."
- "I'll keep this practical if needed. Before that: what's the immediate pressure?"
- "Is this a safety issue, a decision issue, or a support issue?"
- "If action is needed, we'll act. If not, I'm not going to rush you into a fix."
- "If there's immediate safety risk, we act now. If not, I can slow down and understand first. Which is it?"

Digital / text · By message

- "I'm sorry. I won't advice-dump. Want to vent, or do you want help sorting it?"
- "That's a lot. I can read and stay with you first."
- "No fixing unless you want it. What part is hitting hardest?"
- "Want a listening reply or a practical reply?"
- "I'm here. Want me to listen, distract you, or help think through next steps?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You should just talk to them."

Better: "That sounds stressful. Do you want advice?"

Best: "That sounds stressful. I won't jump into fixing it yet. Do you want me to just listen for a minute, or help you sort options after you get it out?"

2. Weak: "At least you know now."

Better: "That must feel disappointing."

Best: "That's disappointing, especially after how much you put into it. I'm not going to silver-line it. What part is sitting heaviest?"

3. Weak: "Here's what I would do."

Better: "I have thoughts if you want them."

Best: "I do have thoughts, but I don't want to rush past what this is like for you. Want listening first, or ideas now?"

DECISION TREE

If There's immediate danger or time-critical action.

Act, escalate, seek appropriate help, or give direct practical support — don't hide behind non-fixing.

"If there's a safety risk, let's deal with that first."

If They explicitly asked for advice, a decision, wording, or a plan.

Switch to permission-based advice: clarify the kind and amount of input they want.

"Happy to. Do you want options, or my honest recommendation?"

If They sound emotionally loaded — vulnerable, ashamed, angry, disappointed, or overwhelmed.

Hold the fix and offer listening first.

"I won't jump into fixing it. What's the hardest part right now?"

If You feel the urge to solve, correct, reassure, diagnose, compare, or silver-line.

Say a non-fixing line before anything else.

"I can feel myself wanting to solve it. Let me not rush you."

If After a reflection, they open up or relax.

Stay in listening mode; don't reach for a plan.

"Keep going — I'm with you."

If They now ask for help.

Offer one concise next step or option set, not a lecture.

"Okay. Want to start with the reply, or the bigger picture?"

SCENARIOS

Friend venting about work

Name the non-fix, then follow the frustration before mentioning any solution. — "That sounds awful. I won't fix it yet — what part is most frustrating?"

Partner sharing family stress

Flag your usual habit of solving, slow down, and ask what they need. — "I know I usually try to solve this. I'm going to slow down. What do you need from me right now?"

Employee overwhelmed by workload

Understand where the pressure comes from before assigning fixes. — "Before I assign fixes, I want to understand where the pressure's actually coming from."

Client or customer upset

Resist the generic fix; understand the disruption first, then offer options. — "I'm not going to rush into a generic fix. First, what has this disrupted for you?"

Text from someone in distress

Keep it short, offer modes, avoid a paragraph of instructions. — "I'm here. I won't advice-dump. Want me to listen, distract you, or help think it through?"

High-stakes situation

Separate genuine urgency from processing; act if there's real risk, otherwise slow down. — "If there's immediate safety risk, we act now. If not, I can slow down and understand first. Which is it?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- There is immediate danger, abuse, a medical emergency, legal risk, or time-critical action
- The person explicitly asks for a concrete answer and the stakes require one
- You are using the pause to dodge a responsibility you actually have
- The person has already said they do not want to discuss feelings
- Your non-fixing stance is turning patronising, slow, or performative
- The person needs a boundary, a decision, a consent check, or direct logistical help

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the reflex

Through the day, each time someone mentions a problem, silently notice the exact moment advice starts forming in you. Don't act on it — just count how often it happens.

Day 2 — Rewrite your reflex

Take five complaints you commonly hear and write your automatic advice for each. Then rewrite each as a non-fixing support line, e.g. "That sounds exhausting. I won't jump into fixing it — what's wearing you down most?"

Day 3 — The three-second delay

In real conversations today, wait three seconds before responding to any problem. In the pause, ask yourself: are they asking for a fix, or asking not to be alone with it?

Day 4 — Name the non-fix out loud

Once today, say a non-fixing line aloud before anything else — "I won't try to solve it yet, I can just listen for a minute" — and watch what the person does next.

Day 5 — Offer the mode menu

Practise offering support modes without sounding stiff: "Do you want listening, comfort, or ideas?" Use one version in a real conversation and follow whichever they choose.

Day 6 — Reflect before you shift

In one conversation, reflect the person's experience at least once ("So the hardest part is not knowing where you stand") before you ask about solutions or offer any.

Day 7 — Practise the repair

Deliberately catch yourself slipping into advice, then recover in one clean sentence: "I jumped into fixing. Let me back up — what's this like for you?" Aim to leave the person feeling accompanied, not managed.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice my fixing reflex before speaking?
- Did I open with presence rather than advice, analysis, or reassurance?
- Did I reflect the person's experience before asking about solutions?
- Did I ask what support mode they wanted?
- Did I move to practical help once they asked for it?
- If I slipped into fixing, did I repair without making them comfort me?